

THE INDIAN WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS

By
George Nidever

Mr. George Nidever's statement, regarding the "Old Indian Woman of the San Nicolas Island", the manner in which she left, and the circumstances connected with the fining off her, is in substance as follows:

In the later part of 1835, in the month of August, he thinks, Usaac J. Sparks, an otter hunter of Santa Barbara, Bill Williams, of the Chino ranch of Los Angeles County and others, some 12 altogether, whose names he does not recollect, went over to the San Nicolas Island in a schooner called the "Peorjes Nada," for the purpose of removing the Indians then inhabiting this Island. They got them together and brought them all, about 17 or 18 men, women and children, down to the beach. Arrived here one of the woman asked permission to return to the Island for her child, which she said had been left behind. She was allowed to go, but during her absence a heavy wind sprang up which compelled them to leave the Island and run before the wind. The San Nicolas is on the outer rim of the channel and affords no shelter whatever for vessels in a storm. The "Peorjes Nada" arrived safely at San Pedro where she landed the Indians, who went up to Los Angeles and from there some of them were taken to the San Gabriel Mission. It was the intention to return for the Indian woman, but the owner of the "Peorjes Nada" ordered her to Monterey, where she loaded with lumber for San Francisco. At the entrance to the Golden Gate she was capsized and there being no other large craft on the coast, no attempt was made to rescue or learn the fate of the Indian woman.

About a month after the removal of the Indians Mr. Nidever joined Mr. Sparks in an otter hunt to the Islands of Santa Rosa, San Miguel, etc. It was from Sparks that he learned the facts of their removal but he either did not learn the object of their removal, or by whose authority they were removed, or if he did learn these facts cannot now recall them. He recollects quite distinctly, however, that Bell Williams was with them and evidently interested in their removal, as he afterwards took one of the Indian women to live with.

It was 1852 before any effort was made to learn the fate of the Indian woman, although it was well known throughtout the coast that she had been abandoned on the Island. In the fall of 1851 Mr. Nidever went over to the San Nicolas to search for sea gull eggs and found footprints of a human being, which from their size he concluded were those of a woman, and the fact that their appearance showed that they had been made but a short time before led him to believe that the Indian woman still existed. A storm coming on drove him from the Island and prevented further search. Upon his return to Santa Barbara he reported his discovery of the footprints to the Mission fathers, who urged him to make a thorough search on his next visit to the Island. This did not occur until the fall of 1852 when he went there on an otter hunting expedition. On this trip he was accompanied by Charley Brown and the first day they went on shore they found a large basket woven of grass in the crotch or fork of a large bush, and in it were several shag skins cut into regular shapes, a dress made of the skins of the same bird, a sinew rope, bone knife, abalone fish hooks and several with a seal skin. They

scattered the things about on the ground and also left the basket lying there, so that they might have some proof of the Indian woman's existence if on their next visit they found the things replaced in the basket, or removed. The next few days they were busy with their hunting, intending to resume the search as soon as their hunting would permit. The third or fourth day, however, a heavy gale sprang up, preventing them from coming ashore and finally forcing them to leave the Island. In the summer of 1853 Mr. Nidever in company with Charley Brown made his third trip to the Island, for the purpose of hunting otter. The day they arrived there they went ashore with the object of seeing where the otter lay, and Brown discovered fresh footprints in the northwest side of the head of the Island, and they decided to make a thorough exploration of the upper portion of the Island the next day. Accordingly the following morning, they took their men ashore and first searched over a low sandy flat covered with dunes and bushes that stretches across the Island about 1-1/2 miles below its head. Nidever took no active part in the search but Brown went across with the men and having found nothing sent them back with instructions to search carefully along the edges of the flat. He remained on that side of the Island and proceeded towards its head until he struck the footprints discovered the evening previous. Following them up over the bank he traced the tracks until they were lost higher up in a soft carpet of moss with which the ground was covered. Between the sand flat already mentioned and the head of the Island there is a long high ridge and it was up on the N.W. side of this that Brown had followed the footprints. From this point he saw three huts further up the ridge, and upon reaching them found them to be made of whale's ribs covered with brush. They were open all around and within the grass was growing thick and high, showing that they had ~~not~~ been occupied for some time. In looking about over the ridge from this point he discovered a small black object at a distance which appeared to be moving and looked to him very much like a crow seated on a bush. He went towards it and soon discovered it to be the Indian Woman. She was seated cross legged on the ground, within a small, low, circular enclosure of sage brush, a specie of windbreak, and was engaged in separating the blubber from a piece of seal skin which she held across one knee with her hand. In the other hand she held a rude knife the blade a piece of iron hook, the handle a rough piece of wood. Within the enclosure or windbreak, a fire was smouldering and without was a large pile of bones and another of ashes, showing that this had been her abode for a long time.

Baskets woven of grass, waterbottles of the same material, made in the shape of a flagon and lined with asphaltum, knives of bone, and other articles lay scattered about. There were no stone mortars or earthen vessels, but there were several shovel or scoop shaped vessels of wood, whose use he did not learn. Stretched between two upright stakes at some distance from the ground was a sinew rope, from which were hanging strips of seal blubber. The situation of the windbreak was about half-way up the ridge on the N.E. side of the Island, so that she received the benefit of the morning sun. The Indian Woman was dressed in a robe or gown of birdskins (the Shag) sewn together with the feathers out and pointing downwards. It was low at the neck, sleeveless and hung down to her ankles (as he afterwards observed) and being girded at the waist with a small rope or cord. This was her only covering. Her feet were bare, as also her head, which was covered with a thick growth of hair

matted, and bleached to a reddish brown and hung down to her shoulders. Her features were quite regular and her complexion fairer than the Indians of the mainland and although she must have been about 50 years old her face was remarkably free from wrinkles. Her teeth were entire and had been, evidently very regular, but they were now worn down to the very gums the result of eating dried seal meat. When he approached her it was from the rear so that she did not see him, although two or three wild dogs that were near her began to growl when they saw him. These she yelled out, without looking around, and they went away. From the elevated point where he stood he signalled to the men who could be seen on the sand flat below, and they came to him, approaching her in a circle so that she could not escape. As soon as they were near enough Brown stepped around in front of her and was surprised to see her smile and bow to him instead of becoming alarmed or startled. As the other men came up she bowed and smiled to them talking rapidly the while but no one could understand her. Nidever then came up and they sat in a circle around her while she roasted some roots and invited them all to partake of them. Nidever feared that force would be necessary to take her with them, but Brown differed from him, and after going through the motions of putting all the things in her baskets and walking off with them towards the beach and saying in Spanish, let us go (vamos) they had the satisfaction of seeing her face brighten up and she began to put her things in her baskets. This done she went with them down to the beach. Here they found a spring and left her things there, she making no objection. Farther on they came to a second spring where she stopped and washed. They then took her on board. They gave her some of their food and she took to it readily. That afternoon Brown made her a dress and skirt of ticking to which was added a man's shirt, a black necktie, and an old cloak. These she continued to wear while on the Island. The following day they went ashore and camped, remaining there about a month. Near their camp they made a small hut or shelter for her and here she remained most of the day, while all of the men excepting the cook were off hunting. She was free to go and come and took frequent walks about the Island but never showed any disposition to leave her rescuers. She busied herself from time to time weaving baskets, and brought wood and water for the cook. She at one time showed a disposition to return to her former food. A she otter was killed and dragged up near the camp to be skinned. After this operation the carcass was being dragged down to the water to prevent it becoming offensive near camp. At sight of what she gave us to understand was an extravagant waste of meat, she rushed down, seized the otter by the flipper and hauled it back. Afterwards when it began to smell she did not object to its being taken away and by signs showed her disgust for it and her preference for their food. On their way to the mainland a heavy storm overtook them and while it lasted she knelt and prayed for it to stop. As she reached the shore, an oxcart and a man on horseback came in sight and her delight was unbounded. She was taken to Mr. Nidever's house where she remained until her death which occurred about 7 weeks later. She was allowed to eat too much fruit and vegetables which ~~she~~ brought on dysentery. The fathers at the Mission sent for Indians from Los Angeles County, San Fernando, and Santa Ynez, beside those of this Mission and San Buena Ventura in the hopes of finding someone who could converse with her, but did not succeed. Her dresses and baskets, etc. were given to Father Gonzalez by whom they were sent to Rome.

Brown's story is in substance the same.

She made them understand by signs that she never found her child and supposed that the dogs had eaten it.

Santa Barbara, Cal.

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(Signed) E. F. Murray

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